

Kigali Business Registration Analysis

2015 – 2024 · Data Analytics Project
Personal Data Analytics Project · April 2026

65.8%	88%	269K	87%
Kigali share of formal businesses (2023)	Registration growth (2015–2024)	Total establishments nationwide (2023)	Business informality rate (2024)

1. Introduction

Kigali is Rwanda's economic heartbeat, consistently accounting for the majority of formal business activity in the country. According to the NISR Integrated Business Enterprise Survey (IBES), Kigali City held 65.8% of all formal businesses in 2023, with its three districts — Gasabo (9.3%), Nyarugenge (8.4%), and Kicukiro (6.3%) — representing the top three most establishment-dense areas in Rwanda. This project analyses trends in business registrations, sectoral composition, the formal–informal divide, and district-level business concentration across the 2015–2024 period.

2. Registration Trend (2015–2024)

New business registrations nationally grew from 13,180 in 2015 to an estimated 24,800 in 2024 — an 88% increase over nine years. The only notable dip was in 2016 (–15%), after which growth resumed steadily. 2024 posted the strongest year-on-year gain at +15.3%.

Year	National Registrations	YoY Change	Kigali Estimate (~68%)
2015	13,180	—	8,962
2016	11,200	–15.0%	7,616
2017	12,400	+10.7%	8,432
2018	13,800	+11.3%	9,384
2019	14,900	+8.0%	10,132
2020	16,105	+8.1%	10,951
2021	17,800	+10.5%	12,104
2022	19,200	+7.9%	13,056
2023	21,500	+12.0%	14,620
2024	24,800	+15.3%	16,864

Note: Kigali estimates derived by applying ~68% Kigali concentration rate (NISR IBES average 2019–2023) to national registration figures. World Bank data covers limited liability corporations only; total enterprise formation including micro and informal is significantly higher.

3. Sectoral Composition (2023)

Wholesale and retail trade dominates the business landscape nationally and in Kigali, accounting for 54.6% of all establishments in 2023 (NISR IBES 2023). Accommodation and food services rank second at 23.0%, reflecting Kigali's growing role as a regional conference and tourism hub. The table below shows the full sectoral breakdown and year-on-year shifts between 2022 and 2023:

Sector	2023 Share (%)	2022 Share (%)	Change (pp)
Wholesale & retail trade	54.6	53.5	+1.1
Accommodation & food services	23.0	22.0	+1.0
Manufacturing	6.2	6.8	−0.6
Professional & business services	5.8	5.5	+0.3
Transport & storage	4.4	4.9	−0.5
Construction	3.2	3.8	−0.6
Other services	2.8	3.5	−0.7

4. Kigali District Analysis

The NISR Establishment Census 2023 shows Kigali's three districts collectively account for 24% of all national establishments despite housing just 17% of Rwanda's population — evidence of Kigali's outsized economic density. Gasabo leads with 9.3% of national establishments, driven by the presence of major commercial zones including the CBD extension and Kimironko market area. Nyarugenge (8.4%) hosts the central business district and Kicukiro (6.3%) is growing rapidly with industrial and residential expansion.

District	Est. Share (% national)	Pop. Share (% Kigali)	Density Index*
Gasabo	9.3%	50.4%	0.18 — Commercial hub
Nyarugenge	8.4%	26.1%	0.32 — CBD & highest density
Kicukiro	6.3%	23.5%	0.27 — Growing industrial zone

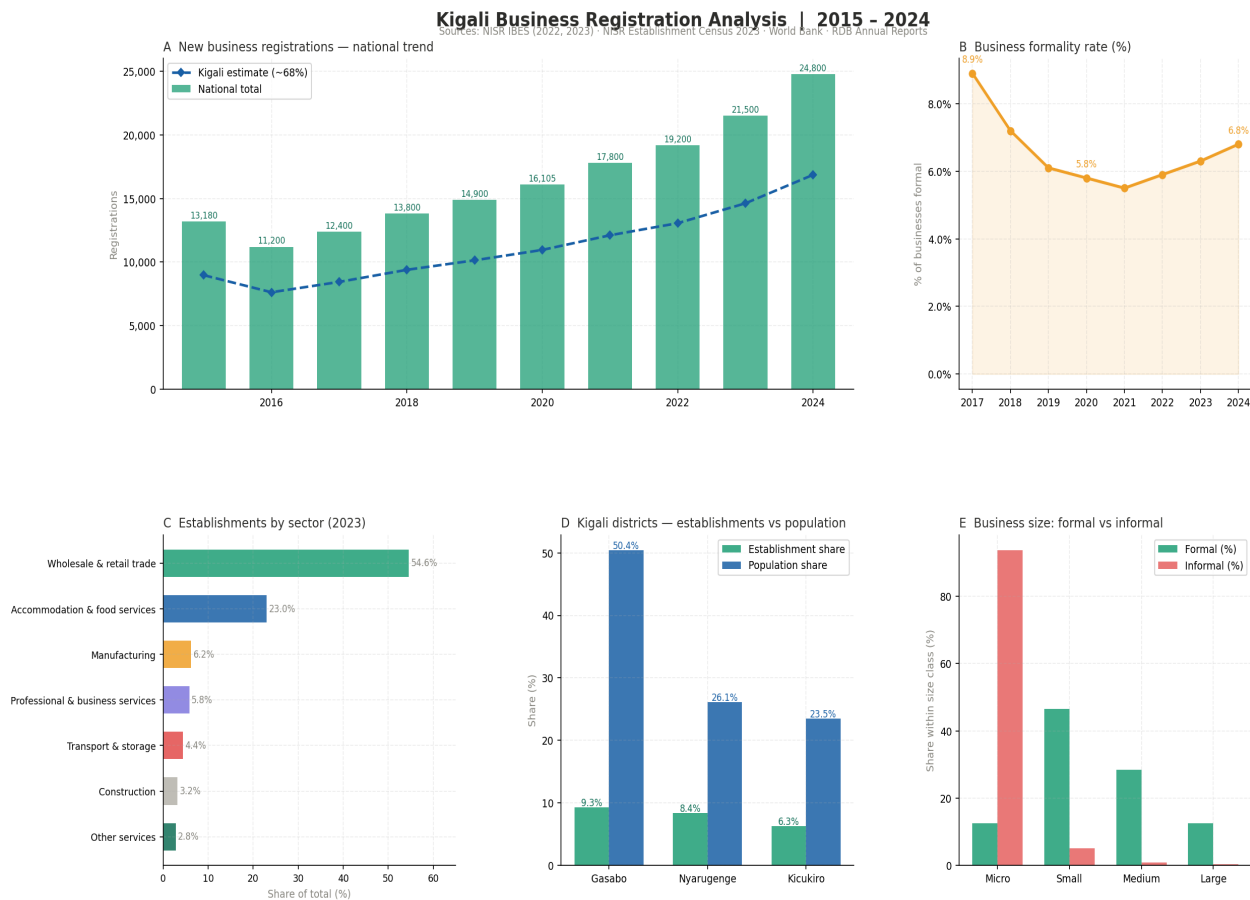
*Density index = est. share ÷ pop. share. Higher = more commercially dense relative to population.

5. Formal vs Informal Business Divide

One of the most persistent structural features of Kigali's business environment is the high rate of informality. Rwanda's overall business informality rate stood at approximately 87% in 2024 (NISR), meaning fewer than 1 in 8 businesses are formally registered. Among micro enterprises (1–3 workers), which make up 83.9% of all business activity, informality reaches 93.7%. Formal enterprises are concentrated among small (46.6% of formal sector) and medium/large businesses. This formality gap presents both a policy challenge and a data limitation — registration statistics capture only the tip of the actual business formation iceberg.

6. Visualisations

The chart below (generated using Python, pandas, and matplotlib) summarises all five dimensions of this analysis in a single multi-panel figure.



7. Key Findings

Business registrations grew 88% between 2015 and 2024

From 13,180 to 24,800 nationally, with Kigali absorbing an estimated ~68% of all formal activity. The 2016 dip (–15%) was temporary; post-2017 growth has been consistent.

Wholesale & retail trade dominates, but services are rising

At 54.6% of establishments, retail remains king — but accommodation & food services at 23% signal Kigali's emergence as a meetings, tourism and hospitality destination.

Informality is the defining structural challenge

87% informality nationally means the true scale of business activity is far larger than registration data suggests. Micro enterprises account for 83.9% of all businesses and 93.7% operate informally.

Nyarugenge is the most commercially dense district

Despite being mid-sized in population terms, Nyarugenge's density index of 0.32 makes it the most commercially concentrated district — driven by the Kigali CBD.

Data Sources

- NISR — Integrated Business Enterprise Survey (IBES) 2022, published December 2023
- NISR — Integrated Business Enterprise Survey (IBES) 2023, published March 2025

- NISR — Establishment Census 2023 (statistics.gov.rw)
- World Bank — New Businesses Registered (IC.BUS.NREG), Rwanda 2006–2020
- Rwanda Development Board (RDB) — Annual Reports 2022 and 2024 (rdb.rw)
- NISR / World Bank — Rwanda 2019–2021 IBES Report, March 2023

Analysis conducted in Python (pandas, matplotlib, numpy). Data accurate as of April 2026. All figures from official NISR/RDB/World Bank sources.